broke out in his camp between Baba Khan Qaqshal and a famously hot-tempered Punjabi called Shahbaz Khan (who would, some years later, take Kumbhalgarh from Rana Pratap).

The Qaqshals had long been with the Mughals in Hindustan; it was a Qaqshal, Majnun Khan, who had introduced Bihari Mal, Akbar's father-in-law, to the young padishah after the Kachhwaha chief negotiated his surrender of Narnaul. In the 1570s, most of the Qaqshals were in the east with Munim Khan, but some of them had been separated from their tribe and enlisted in Akbar's Gujarat expedition.

This transfer was part of a larger policy of dispersing clans across the realm, to prevent the kind of accumulation of forces that had allowed the Uzbeks their rebellion. It was soon after the Uzbeks were defeated, in fact, that Akbar broke up the ataka khail, his foster father's increasingly powerful family, posting the various uncles, brothers and nephews out of Punjab. Only Aziz, Akbar's favourite, was allowed to remain in his fief.[22]

Akbar was right: much as a union of workers is a greater threat to a corporation than one disgruntled employee, a clan with shared interests could exert far more pressure on the imperial centre than a lone rebel. Now, for example, rumours of the quarrel between Baba Khan Qaqshal and Shahbaz Khan reached the east, and caused an uproar. Some 'idle talkers and liars', writes Abul Fazl, had exaggerated news of the fight and its consequences; it was rumoured that Baba Khan and the other Qaqshals in the camp had killed Shahbaz Khan and joined the Mirzas' rebellion. In retaliation, Akbar had ordered all the Qaqshals in the east to be arrested. The eastern Qaqshals panicked and abandoned Munim Khan; and Akbar might have found himself fighting revolts on two fronts had the Qaqshals in Gujarat not sent a reassuring letter to their kin in the east, who returned to Munim Khan amid an exchange of '[v]arious courtesies'.

In 1580, the conciliatory Munim was long gone. Instead, there was Muzaffar Khan.

Whether as accountant or as governor, Muzaffar Khan lacked the geniality of spirit that is so necessary to lead men – if not to browbeat and command them. Instead, writes Abul Fazl, 'the forehead of his heart [was] full of wrinkles'. Badauni tells the story of one Khalidi Khan, a noble 'of great importance', positively begging to be excused from branding. The